

AFP PHOTO



**TARGET PRACTICE:** An Indian soldier in Congo

## Alone in Africa

**DELHI** An inquiry ordered by the Indian Army and headed by a three-star general has recommended disciplinary action against three Indian soldiers posted in the UN mission in the central African country of Congo. The soldiers had detained and threatened a local who

had sold them fake gold dust. With over 8,000 UN peacekeepers involved in six different peacekeeping missions across the globe, the second largest contributor of troops to the UN is anxious to prevent any damage to its reputation. Congo has been wracked by Africa's widest civil

strife for over a decade.

However, the UN is befuddled by the alarming periodicity of reports of allegations against Indian troops in Congo. Four anonymous complaints made to the UN mission this year alleged that Indian peacekeepers were smuggling gold, trading arms and rations to the rebels, molesting local women and not deploying attack helicopters. The

UN's Office of Internal Oversight, however, found these to be false.

Equally befuddling is the silence from the Ministry of External Affairs and the Indian mission in Congo which, the army says, has tacitly allowed mud to stick to the Indian troops. It illustrates how India's diplomatic footprint is minuscule compared to its military footprint in a resource-rich nation. When peace returns to the warring country and the contracts for rebuilding infrastructure and exploiting mineral resources are handed out, nations which have contributed peacekeepers to the government are likely to be key beneficiaries. Targeting the Indian peacekeepers could well be part of a bigger game plan to keep India out of Congo. **by Sandeep Unnikrishnan**

### THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The Government has already won its first 'trust vote' as the appointment of a "neutral" from the Nagaland cadre as the new petroleum secretary puts an end to speculation that the new incumbent will be handpicked by big business.

### VOICES

"Just because some Left leaders are co-travellers with me on the Rajdhani Express, it doesn't mean that I have to get off the train."

Venkaiah Naidu, BJP leader

"As long as they were dependent on the Left, the UPA used to say 'lal salaam'. Now they are saying 'dalaal salaam'."

L.K. Advani, leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha

"Rajiv Gandhi had voted along with the BJP to oust the V.P. Singh government. In that condition, will the Congress call its own leader communal for voting along with BJP?"

Ravi Shankar Prasad, BJP spokesman

"The investigation against her (Mayawati) in the corruption cases has been going on for a long time. However, with the change in political arithmetic, it has suddenly gained pace."

Uma Bharati, Bharatiya Janshakti Party chief

"They (English medium schools) are free to teach German or French or any other language, but Marathi cannot be an optional language in Maharashtra."

Raj Thackeray, Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief